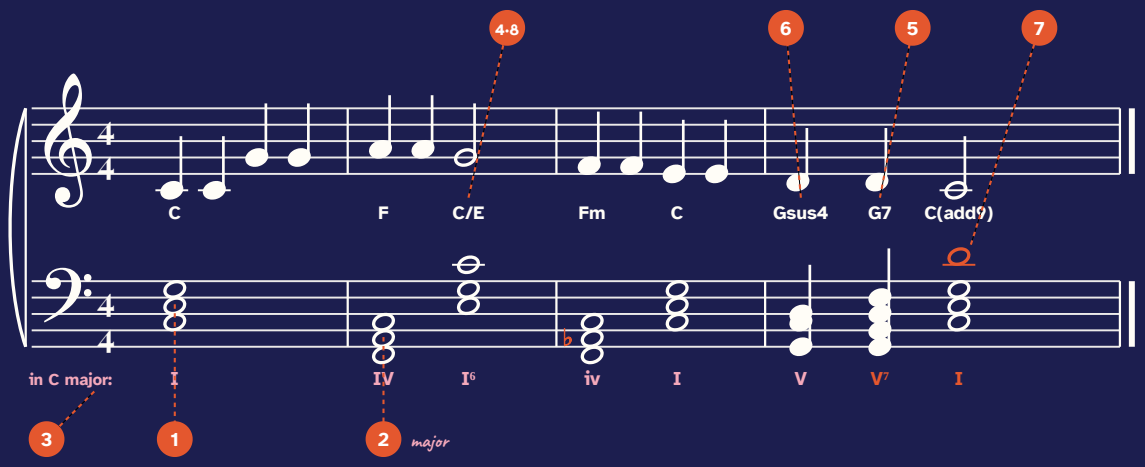
PART IV · BUILD THEM

Chords

Press three notes at once and you have a chord. Stack them, name them, turn them upside down, add floors. Every chapter of this part is in these four bars of Twinkle.



1 **Chords and triads** p. 87
three notes stacked like a snowman

2 **Four kinds of triad** p. 90
major 3 + 2, minor 2 + 3

3 **Chords in a key** p. 93
Roman numerals: I, IV and V do most of the work

4 **Inversions** p. 96
the same notes, a different one at the bottom

5 **Seventh chords** p. 99
one more floor: G7 pulls home

6 **Colour chords** p. 102
sus and add: a note moved or added

7 **The tower: 9, 11, 13** p. 105
keep skipping a letter

8 **Slash chords** p. 108
C/E: the chord, then the bass note

★ **Tips: when a chord sounds wrong** p. 111

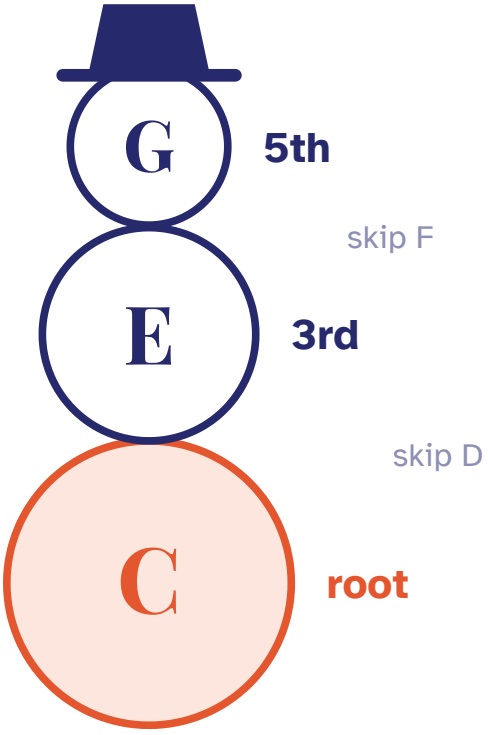
PART IV · CHORDS · 1

Chords and triads

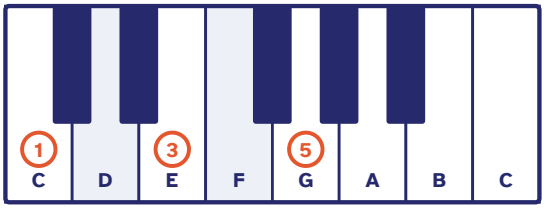
Press two or more notes at once and you have a **chord**. The favourite of all is the **triad**: three notes stacked like a snowman.

THE SECRET

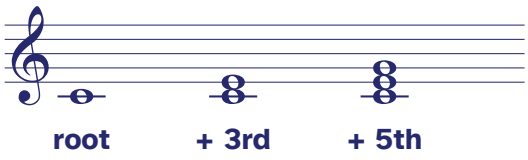
Play one, skip one, play one: the snowman rule.



1. Pick a note: the **root**, the big ball at the bottom. It holds the chord up and gives it its name.
2. Skip one letter, take the next: **E**, the **3rd**.
3. Skip again: **G**, the **5th**. C E G is the triad of C.



On the keys: play one, skip one (shaded), play one, skip one, play one.



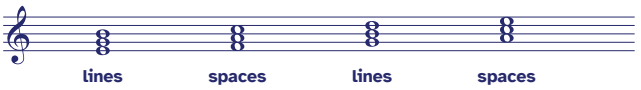
The snowman on the staff: three lines in a row (or three spaces).

On the staff, each ball sits on the **next line up** (or the next space up): the root, a **3rd** above it, a **5th** above the root.

First met: Level ½ (the tonic triad of C, G and F major).

All lines or all spaces

A stacked triad sits on **three lines in a row** or in **three spaces in a row**, in a neat stack. If one note breaks the pattern, it is not a triad.



Lines, spaces, lines, spaces: every one a triad.

PART IV · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

Solid and broken

Played together, a chord is **solid** (or blocked). Played one note at a time, it is **broken**. Spread up and down the keyboard, a broken chord becomes an **arpeggio**. Left-hand accompaniments, the arpeggios in technical work and the chord names over a song are all triads.

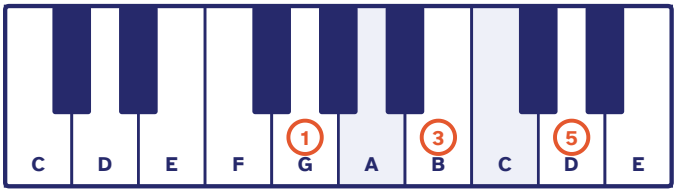
First met: Level 0; arpeggios from Level 1.



The same three notes, solid then broken.

EXAMPLE 1

Build a triad on G



1. **Start on G:** the root.
2. **Skip A, play B:** the 3rd.
3. **Skip C, play D:** the 5th.

G B D: the triad of **G**. Same shape as C E G, just moved up.

EXAMPLE 2

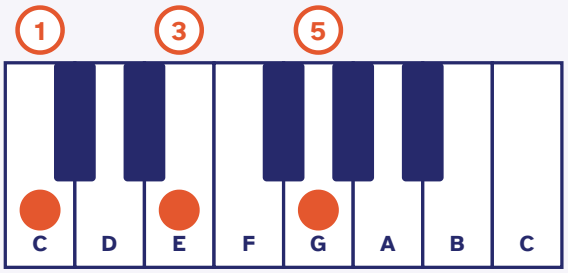
Is it a triad?



1. **Chord 1:** D F A, all in spaces, each a 3rd apart: **a triad**.
2. **Chord 2:** D E A: D to E is a 2nd. **Not a triad.**
3. **Chord 3:** D G C, stacked in 4ths. **Not a triad.**

Only chord 1 is a triad. Check that each note is a **3rd** above the one below.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C. Fingers 1, 3, 5 down together.

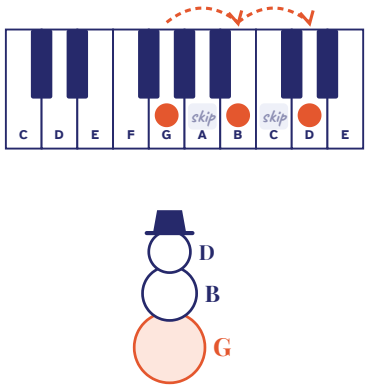
That is the C chord. Slide your hand to any white key and do it again: the snowman shape always works.

PART IV · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

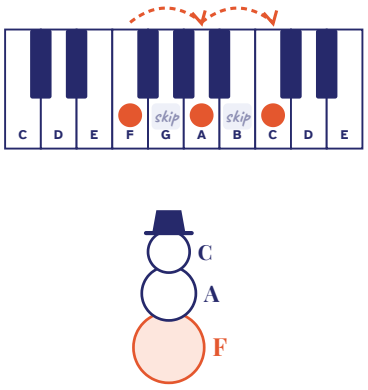
Build one yourself

G



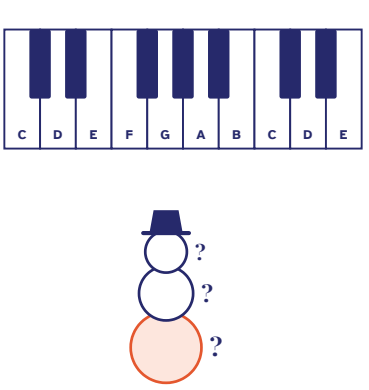
Start on G: **G B D**.

F



Start on F: **F A C**.
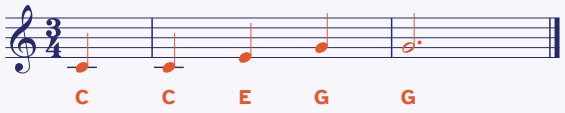
?



Your turn: start on **A**. Which three keys?

Build the snowman on A: play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one.

Answer: A C E, the A minor chord.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Blue Danube (Johann Strauss II), here in C



The most famous waltz tune simply climbs the **C triad**: **C, C E G, G**. Root, 3rd, 5th, then it holds the top: that is why it sounds so open.

Try it. Play C E G one at a time, then hum the waltz over it.

THINK OF IT Solid: three friends shout “Hello!” together. Broken: each says it in turn.

TRAP

- × Stacking 2nds or 4ths: a triad skips exactly one letter each time.
- × Naming a chord from its top note: the root names it (at the bottom when the notes are stacked in 3rds).

SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 38 · Major scales p. 70

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 1 · Online: Library › Chords

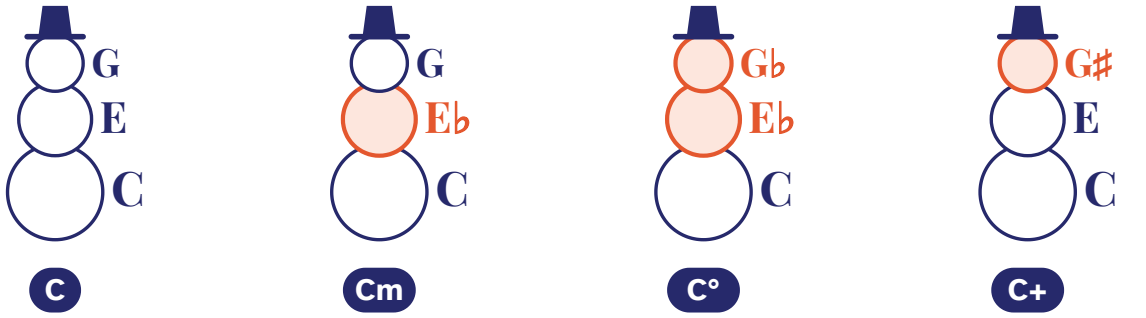
PART IV · CHORDS · 2

Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

THE SECRET

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.

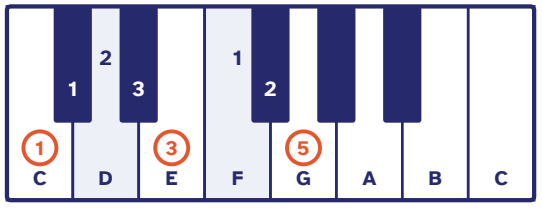


Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor

KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	CHORD NAME	FIRST MET
major	**3 + 2**	C E G	C	Level ½
minor	**2 + 3**	C E♭ G	Cm	Level 2
diminished	**2 + 2**	C E♭ G♭	C° or Cdim	Level 5
augmented	**3 + 3**	C E G♯	C+ or Caug	Level 6

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. 41).

Count the keys in between



Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

PART IV · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

The seven white-key triads, sorted



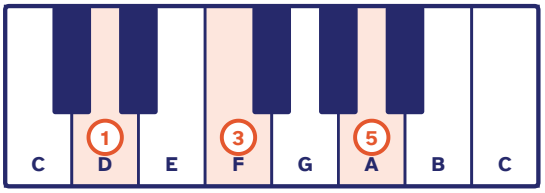
Always the same on the white keys: **three major** (C, F, G), **three minor** (D, E, A), **one diminished** (B), no augmented. In any major key, chords I, IV and V are the major ones (p. 93).

How they sound

KIND	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
major	bright, settled, open	most cheerful tunes, fanfares
minor	darker, softer, sadder	lullabies, laments, film tension
diminished	tense, unstable, wants to move	suspense, the chord before home
augmented	floating, dreamy, unsettled	dream scenes, a passing colour

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor? D F A



1 **Root to 3rd:** D to F skips D♯ and E: **2**.

2 **3rd to 5th:** F to A skips F♯, G and G♯: **3**.

3 **2 + 3** is minor.

D F A is **D minor** (Dm). Three of the white-key triads are minor: D, E and A.

GAME

Which kind?



1 2 3

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 major, 2 + 3 minor, 2 + 2 diminished, 3 + 3 augmented.

Answer: 1 diminished · 2 major · 3 augmented.

PART IV · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

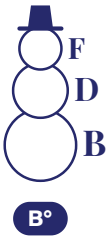


C E G, then C E♭ G, then C E♭ G♭.

Bright, dark, tense. Only the middle ball moves first, then the top one. Listen for the change each time.

EXAMPLE 2

Build a triad on B
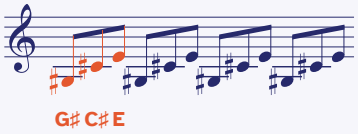


1. **Skip a letter:** B, D, F.
2. **Count the keys between:** B to D, 2 (C, C♯); D to F, 2 (D♯, E).
3. **2 + 2:** diminished.

B D F is **B diminished** (B°): the only diminished triad on the white keys.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)



The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two floors of a building: a tall floor (3 keys between) and a short one (2). Major: tall, then short, 3 + 2. Minor: short, then tall, 2 + 3. Diminished: two short, 2 + 2. Augmented: two tall, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO
Chords and triads p. 87 · Major, minor and perfect p. 41

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 2 · Online: Library › Chords

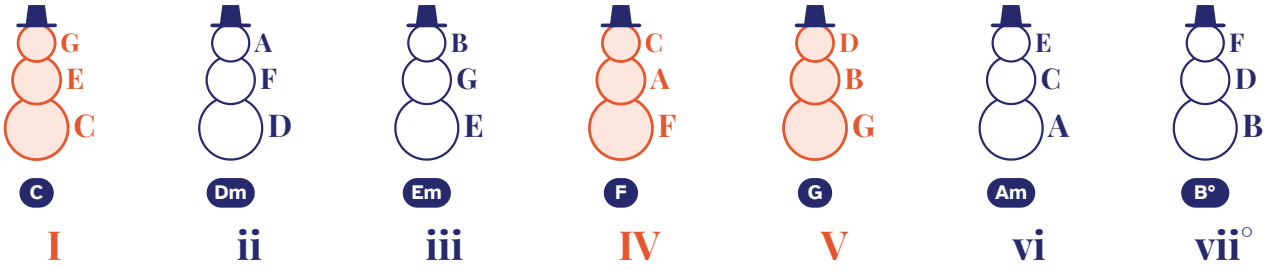
PART IV · CHORDS · 3

Chords in a key
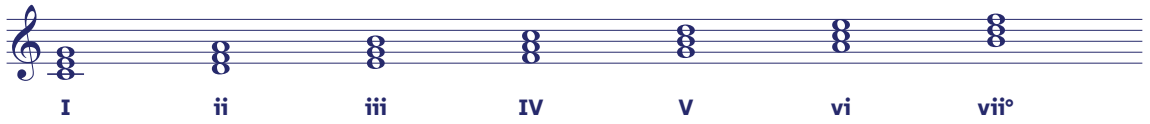
Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

THE SECRET

Build a snowman on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.



One snowman on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work



The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 91.

NUMERAL	NAME	KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	IN C	IN G
I	tonic	major	3 + 2	C	G
ii	supertonic	minor	2 + 3	Dm	Am
iii	mediant	minor	2 + 3	Em	Bm
IV	subdominant	major	3 + 2	F	C
V	dominant	major	3 + 2	G	D
vi	submediant	minor	2 + 3	Am	Em
vii°	leading note	diminished	2 + 2	B°	F♯°

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Levels 1–2; the other chords from about Level 4.

The three primary chords
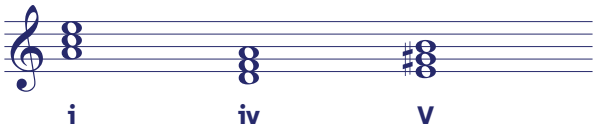
I, IV and V are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

THINK OF IT I is home. IV is a visit next door. V is the walk back, already looking at the front door: it wants to go home to I. Play C, F, G, C and hear it.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

In a minor key

In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th**, G♯, which pulls up to the home note A. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.



A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

Which chord holds the note?

NOTE IN C	C	D	E	F	G	A	B
Chord	I or IV	V	I	IV	I or V	IV	V

The same idea works in every key: find which of I, IV and V holds the note.

EXAMPLE 1

Find I, IV and V in G major



1. **Count up the scale:** G A B C D. The 1st note is G, the 4th C, the 5th D.
2. **Build a triad on each,** using the key signature: the F is F♯.
3. **Check with the keys between:** all three are 3 + 2, major.

In G major: **I = G**, **IV = C**, **V = D** (D F♯ A).

GAME

Which numeral?



All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



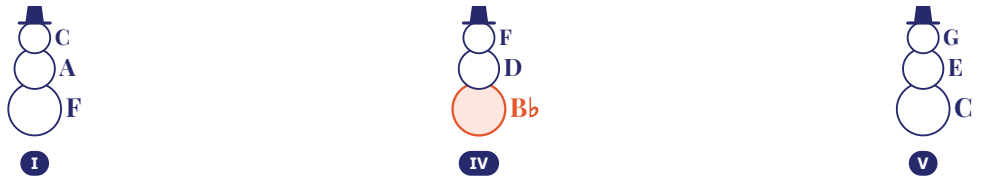
Left hand: I IV V I.

C, F, G, C, one chord per bar, four beats each. The three primary chords: nearly every nursery tune fits them.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find I, IV and V in F major

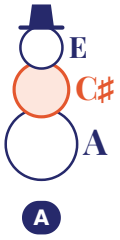


1. **Count up the scale:** F G A B♭ C. The 1st note is F, the 4th B♭, the 5th C.
2. **Build a triad on each,** with the key signature's B♭.
3. **Check:** all three are 3 + 2, major.

In F major: **I = F**, **IV = B♭**, **V = C**.

EXAMPLE 3

Find V in D minor



1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A.
2. **Build the triad:** A C E.
3. **Raise the 7th note of the scale,** C to C♯: A C♯ E, major.

V in D minor is **A major**: the C♯ pulls up to D.

YOU KNOW THIS

The twelve-bar blues

I C	I C	I C	I C
IV F	IV F	I C	I C
V G	IV F	I C	V G

Almost every blues, and a lot of rock 'n' roll, is just **I, IV and V** in twelve bars. Learn this chart and you can play along with hundreds of songs.

Try it. Play the chart in C with your left hand, one chord per bar, four beats each.

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 90 · Major scales p. 70 · Cadences p. 116

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 3 · Online: Library › Chords

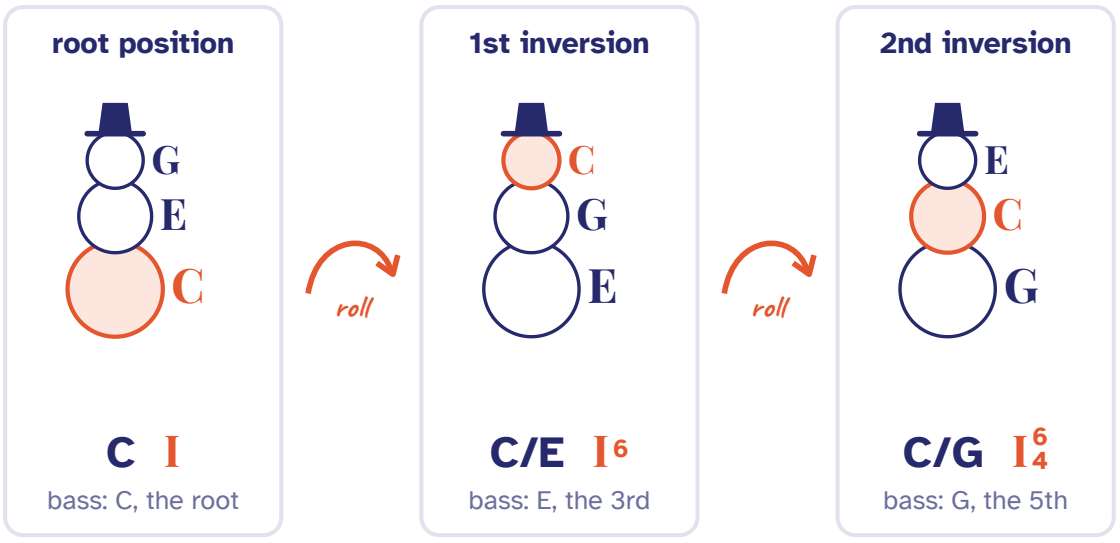
PART IV · CHORDS · 4

Inversions

Same three notes, a different one at the bottom. The chord keeps its name; only the bass changes. The red ball is the root, C: watch it travel.

THE SECRET

Move the bottom note to the top: same chord, new bass.

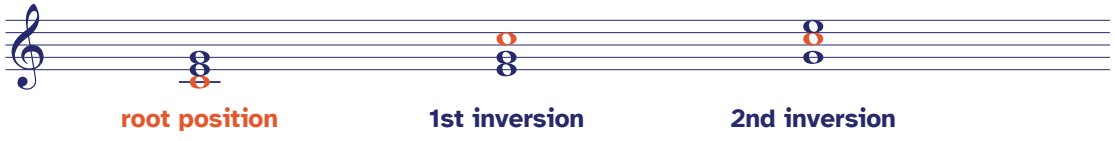


1. Start with the snowman **C E G**: root at the bottom.
2. Roll the bottom ball to the top: **E G C**. That is the 1st inversion.
3. Roll again: **G C E**, the 2nd inversion. Still **C major**.

Two ways to write it

	ROOT POSITION	1ST INVERSION	2ND INVERSION
Chord symbol pop, jazz	C	C/E	C/G
Harmony class numerals	I	I^6	I^6_4
Also written	Ia, 5/3	Ib, 6/3	Ic, 6/4
First met	Level ½	Level 3	Level 5

The little numbers count up from the bass. E G C: C is a **6th** above E, so I^6. G C E: E is a 6th and C a **4th** above G, so I^6_4. A slash chord just names the bass: C/E (more on p. 108).



The same three chords on the staff; the red note is the root, C. To find the root, restack the notes every other letter (like C E G): then the bottom ball is the root.

PART IV · CHORDS · 4 · CONTINUED

Why inversions?

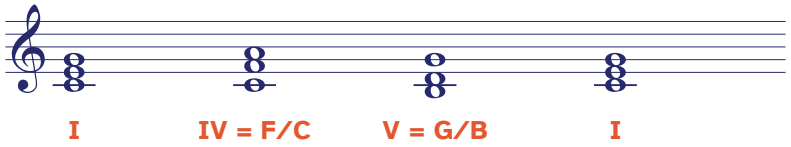
They let your hand **move as little as possible**: keep any note two chords share, and move the others to the nearest note of the next chord. Left-hand accompaniments and hymn parts are written this way.

Chords of C, every position

CHORD	ROOT POSITION	1ST INVERSION	2ND INVERSION
I (C)	C E G	E G C	G C E
IV (F)	F A C	A C F	C F A
V (G)	G B D	B D G	D G B
vi (Am)	A C E	C E A	E A C

EXAMPLE 1

Play I, IV, V, I smoothly



1. **I:** C E G. **IV:** keep C, move E up to F and G up to A: C F A.
2. **V:** no shared note. C steps down to B, F down to D, A down to G: B D G.
3. **I again:** B up to C, D up to E, G stays: C E G.

IV is F/C and V is G/B: **inversions** keep the hand in one place.

GAME

Which position?

1	2	3
C E G	E G C	G C E

Same three notes. Look at the bottom one: root, 3rd or 5th?

Answer: 1 root position · 2 first inversion (C/E) · 3 second inversion (C/G).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Climb the chord.

Play C E G, then E G C, then G C E, then C E G an octave up. Same snowman, turning over as it climbs.

PART IV · CHORDS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Write F major in first inversion



1. **F major:** F A C.
2. **First inversion:** the 3rd, A, goes to the bottom.
3. **Stack it:** A C F.

First inversion of F: **A C F**, written **F/A** or **IV⁶** in C.

EXAMPLE 3

Find the second inversion of G
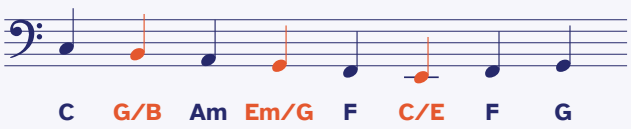


1. **G major:** G B D.
2. **Second inversion:** the 5th, D, goes to the bottom.
3. **Stack it:** D G B.

Second inversion of G: **D G B**, written **G/D** or **V⁶₄** in C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Pachelbel's Canon, the bass (here in C)



In the popular version the bass walks **straight down the scale**: C B A G F E. It can, because some chords are **inversions**: G/B, Em/G and C/E put a different note in the bass.

Try it. Play the bass slowly and hum the famous violin tune over it.

THINK OF IT The same three friends in a photo, swapping places: still the same group (the same chord), but whoever stands at the front (the bass) changes the picture.

TRAP

- × Naming a chord from its bass note: in an inversion the bass is not the root. Restack it in 3rds first.
- × Thinking an inversion is a new chord: E G C is still C major.

SEE ALSO

Chords and triads p. 87 · Chords in a key p. 93 · Cadences p. 116

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 4 · Online: Library › Chords

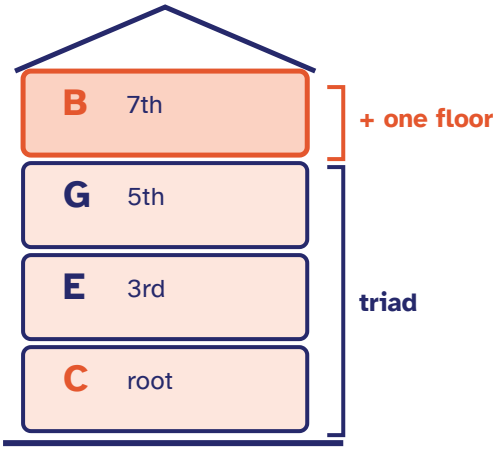
PART IV · CHORDS · 5

Seventh chords

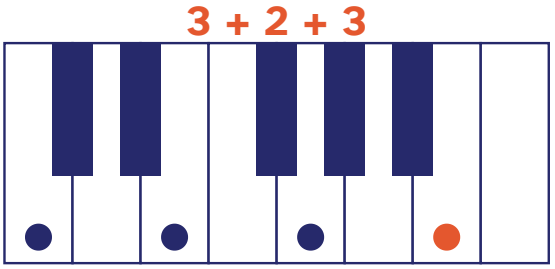
Add one more floor to a triad and the chord changes colour: dreamy, bluesy, spooky. Same rule as before: skip one note, stack the next. The new note is the **7th**.

THE SECRET

One more floor on the snowman and the chord changes colour.

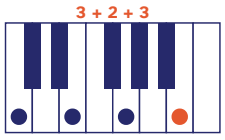


1. Build the triad: **C E G**.
2. Skip one, add the next: **B**.
3. Count the keys between: **3 + 2 + 3**. That is **Cmaj7**.



Five flavours, all on C

Cmaj7

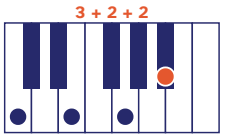


C E G B

dreamy

bossa nova, film

C7

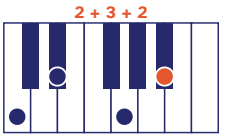


C E G B♭

bluesy

the blues

Cm7

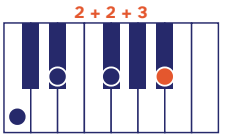


C E♭ G B♭

mellow

soul, jazz ballads

Cø7

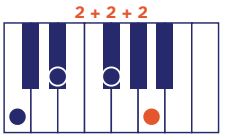


C E♭ G♭ B♭

searching

Bø7 is ii in A minor

C°7
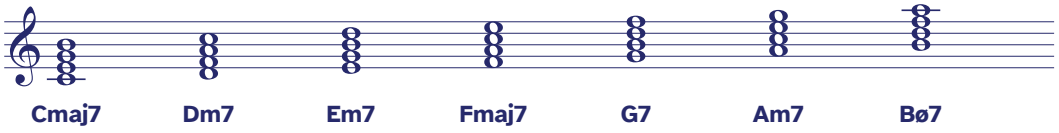


C E♭ G♭ B𝄫 (= A)

spooky

old film villains

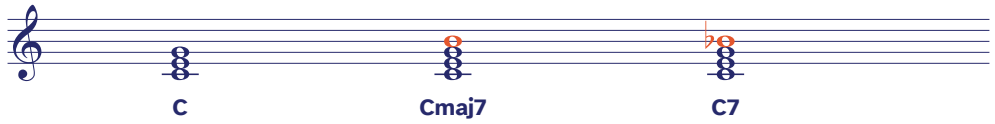
How the names work: major triad + major 7th = **maj7** · major triad + minor 7th = **7** · minor triad + minor 7th = **m7** · diminished triad + minor 7th = **ø7** · diminished triad + diminished 7th = **°7**. Also written: CM7 or CΔ = Cmaj7, C–7 = Cm7, Cm7♭5 = Cø7, Cdim7 = C°7.

A seventh on every floor of C major

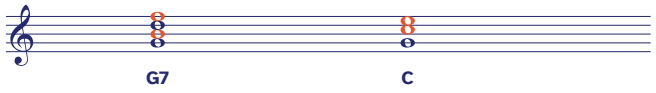


Only white keys. G7 is the one with the strongest pull home.

PART IV · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED



One note decides: B makes Cmaj7, B♭ makes C7. Everything below stays the same.



Why G7 pulls home: its B wants to rise to **C** and its F wants to fall to **E**. Two small steps, and you are home in C.

Spot the difference

EXAMPLE 1

Which seventh is it? G B D F



G B D F

1. **Count the keys between:** G to B is 3, B to D is 2, D to F is 2.
2. **3 + 2 + 2** is the bluesy one.
3. **The root is G:** G7.

G B D F is **G7**, the chord that pulls hardest back to C.

GAME

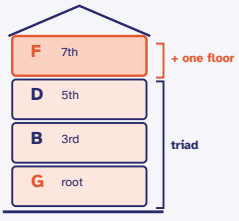
Which seventh?

1	2	3
F A C E	C E G B♭	D F A C

A triad with one more floor. Name each chord.

Answer: 1 Fmaj7 · 2 C7 · 3 Dm7.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



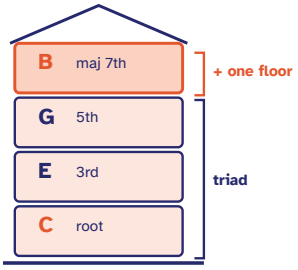
Play G7, then C.

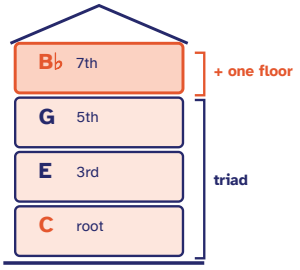
G B D F, hold it, then C E G. The F in G7 leans on E; the B leans up to C. That lean is the pull home.

PART IV · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Build Cmaj7, then C7





1. **Start with C major:** C E G.
2. **Add B**, one key below the top C: Cmaj7, dreamy.
3. **Lower it to B♭:** C7, the bluesy one that wants to move.

One key decides it: **B** is Cmaj7, **B♭** is C7.

HOW TO

Hear the four sevenths

1. **Play C7, Cmaj7, Cm7 and Cø7** slowly, one after another.
2. **Name the feeling** of each: bluesy, dreamy, mellow, searching.
3. **Then play one** without looking and guess which it is.

YOU KNOW THIS

The blues, with sevenths

I C7	I C7	I C7	I C7
IV F7	IV F7	I C7	I C7
V G7	IV F7	I C7	V G7

Swap the triads for **7th chords** and the twelve-bar chart (p. 95) turns into the real blues: the 7th is the blue note.

Try it. Play the chart with plain C, F and G first (p. 94), then add the red 7ths: B♭, E♭ and F.

THINK OF IT A triad is plain toast; the 7th is the topping: same bread, new taste.

TRAP

- × Writing C7 when you mean Cmaj7: "7" alone means the bluesy one, with B♭.
- × Stacking the 7th from the wrong note: count a 7th up from the root, not from the 5th.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 90 · Chords in a key p. 93

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 5 · Online: Library › Chords

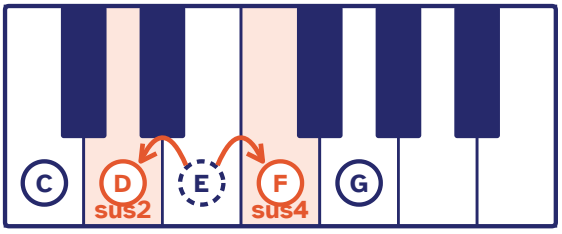
PART IV · CHORDS · 6

Colour chords

The 3rd is the chord's mood: major or minor, happy or sad. Slide it aside, take it away, or add one note, and a plain chord takes on a new colour. Five colours, all from C E G.

THE SECRET

Move the 3rd, take it away, or add one note: five new colours.

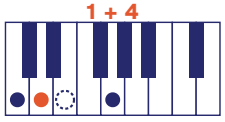


1. Start from **C E G**. The **E** (the 3rd) makes it major.
2. Slide the E up to the next letter, **F**: **Csus4**.
3. Or down to the letter below, **D**: **Csus2**. With no 3rd, the chord is neither major nor minor: it **hangs in the air**.

Five colours, all on C

Csus2

1 + 4



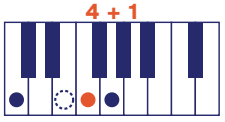
C D G

open

the 3rd steps down

Csus4

4 + 1



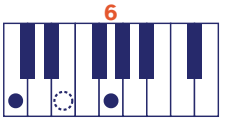
C F G

floating

the 3rd steps up

C5

6



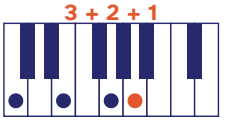
C G

strong

no 3rd at all

C6

3 + 2 + 1



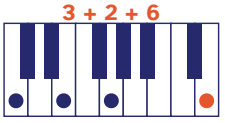
C E G A

warm

add the 6th

Cadd9

3 + 2 + 6

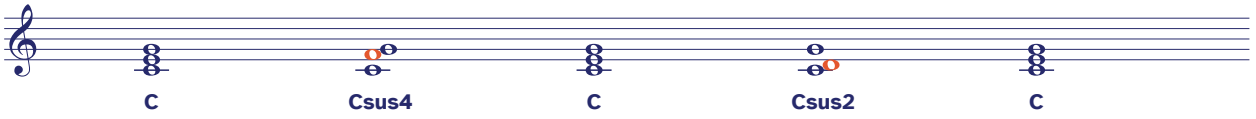


C E G D

sparkly

add the 9th on top

Sus wants to come home



The red note leans, then slides back to E: F steps down, D steps up. Play it slowly: C, Csus4, C, Csus2, C. Guitarists love this shimmer.

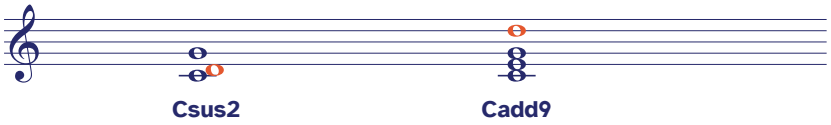
On any root, the counts stay the same

COLOUR	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	ON G	ON F	ON D
sus2	1 + 4	C D G	G A D	F G C	D E A
sus4	4 + 1	C F G	G C D	F B♭ C	D G A
5	6	C G	G D	F C	D A
6	3 + 2 + 1	C E G **A**	G B D **E**	F A C **D**	D F♯ A **B**
add9	3 + 2 + 6	C E G **D**	G B D **A**	F A C **G**	D F♯ A **E**

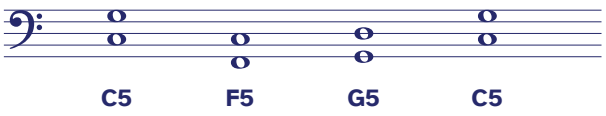
PART IV · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

sus: the 3rd held up or down · **5**: no 3rd at all · **6** and **add9**: one note added on top. Csus means Csus4.

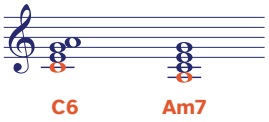
Spot the difference



The same red D, two jobs. Csus2 throws the E out; Cadd9 keeps the E and puts the D on top.



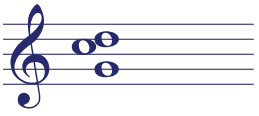
The power chord: just the root and the 5th, played low in the left hand. With no 3rd it is neither happy nor sad, only **strong**: the sound of rock guitar. Play C5, F5, G5, C5 and drum the rhythm.



C6 or Am7? The same four notes, C E G A. The red bottom note decides: C at the bottom is **C6**; A at the bottom is **Am7**. More on the bass note in Slash chords, p. 108.

EXAMPLE 1

Which colour is it? G C D



1. **Count the keys between:** G to C is 4, C to D is 1.
2. **4 + 1** is the sus4 card: no B (no 3rd), and C has taken its place.
3. **The root is G:** Gsus4.

G C D is **Gsus4**. Let the C fall to **B** and you have G major.

GAME

sus2, sus4 or add9?

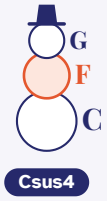
1	2	3
C D G	C F G	C E G D

In a sus chord the 3rd has moved; in an add chord nothing moved and a note was added.

Answer: 1 Csus2 · 2 Csus4 · 3 Cadd9.

PART IV · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Csus4, then C.

Play C F G, then let the F slide down to E. The sus chord waits; the plain chord arrives.

EXAMPLE 2

Build Dsus4

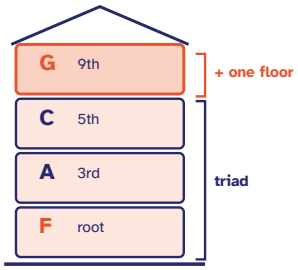


1. **Start with D major:** D F♯ A.
2. **Lift the 3rd, F♯, up a step** to G.
3. **D G A** waits; let the G fall back to F♯ to finish.

Dsus4: **D G A**, then home to D F♯ A.

EXAMPLE 3

Build Fadd9



1. **Start with F major:** F A C.
2. **Keep every note.**
3. **Add the 9th:** G, the note just above F, placed on top.

Fadd9: **F A C G**. Nothing moved; one note was added.

THINK OF IT Dressing the snowman: a scarf (the 6th) or a hat (the 9th) and it is still the same snowman. Sus moves its middle ball; a power chord takes the middle ball away.

TRAP

- × Writing C2: some books mean Csus2, others Cadd9. Check whether the E is there.
- × Calling Cadd9 a ninth chord: C9 also has the 7th (B♭). Add9 is just the triad plus the 9th (D on C), nothing else (The tower, p. 105).

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 90 · Seventh chords p. 99

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 6 · Online: Library › Chords

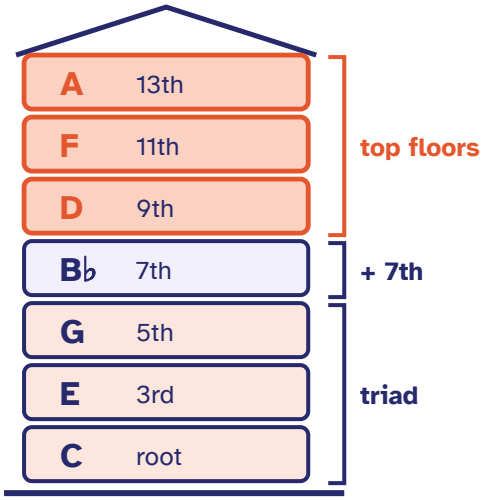
PART IV · CHORDS · 7

The tower: 9, 11, 13

Why stop at the 7th? Keep stacking 3rds and the building grows three more floors: the 9th, the 11th and the 13th. At the top you have used **all seven letters, A to G**.

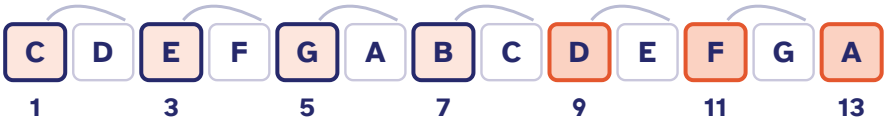
THE SECRET

Keep skipping letters above the 7th: 9, 11, 13 are 2, 4, 6 an octave up.



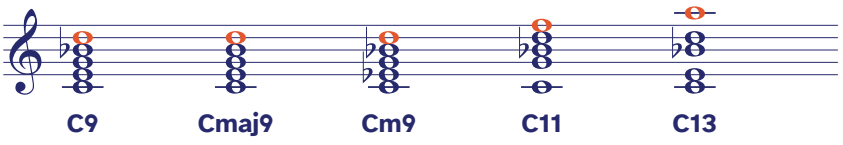
1. Build the seventh chord: **C E G B♭** (C7).
2. Keep skipping one letter: **D**, **F**, **A**. Those floors are the **9th, 11th and 13th**.
3. Take 7 away to find the letter: 9 → 2nd (D), 11 → 4th (F), 13 → 6th (A). Same letters, an octave up.

Skip a letter, all the way up



Start on C and take every other letter: C E G B D F A (letters only: in C7 the B is B♭). After the 13th comes C again: the tower is full.

Five tall chords on C

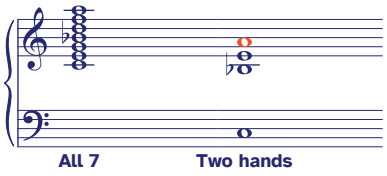


The red note is the top floor that gives each chord its name. C11 and C13 leave some notes out: see p. 106.

CHORD	BUILT AS	NOTES	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
C9	C7 + 9th	C E G B♭ **D**	soulful	funk, soul
Cmaj9	Cmaj7 + 9th	C E G B **D**	dreamy	film, ballads
Cm9	Cm7 + 9th	C E♭ G B♭ **D**	smooth	neo-soul, R&B
C11	C9 + 11th, no 3rd	C G B♭ D **F**	airy	gospel, pop
C13	C7 + 13th	C E B♭ (D) **A**	rich	jazz, blues endings

PART IV · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

Too many notes? Leave some out



All seven notes sound muddy. Two hands play C13 with four: C in the left hand, B♭ E A in the right.

Ten fingers, seven floors: you choose. **Keep** the 3rd and the 7th (they say what kind of chord it is) and the red top note (its colour). **Leave out** the 5th first. The right hand can drop the root too, when the left hand or a bass player plays it.

With a major 3rd, the 11th (F) rubs against E. So C13 leaves out the F. C11 does the opposite: it keeps the F and leaves out the E.

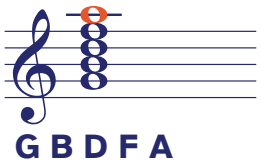
6 or 13? add9 or 9?

SAME TOP NOTE	WITHOUT THE 7TH	WITH THE 7TH (B♭)
A on C	**C6**: C E G A	**C13**: C E B♭ A
D on C	**Cadd9**: C E G D	**C9**: C E G B♭ D

Look for the 7th. No 7th: a colour chord (p. 102). A 7th: a tower chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name this tall chord: G B D F A



1. **Find the root:** each note skips one letter, so the bottom note, G, is the root.
2. **The first four floors**, G B D F, count 3 + 2 + 2: G7.
3. **One more floor:** A is the 2nd above G, an octave up: the 9th.

G B D F A is **G9**: G7 with the 9th on top.

GAME

Which floor?

1 — the 9th of C

2 — the 11th of C

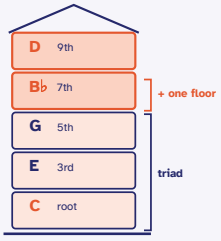
3 — the 13th of C

Build C7 (C E G B♭), then keep skipping one letter above the B♭.

Answer: 1 D · 2 F · 3 A.

PART IV · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

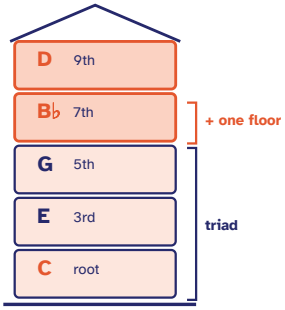


Play C E G B♭ D.

Both hands if you need them: left hand C E G, right hand B♭ D. A C9: the tower with one floor above the 7th.

EXAMPLE 2

Build C9



1. **Build C7:** C E G B♭.
2. **Skip one more letter** above B♭: D.
3. **Five notes:** share them between the hands if you need to.

C9: **C E G B♭ D**, the tower with one floor above the 7th.

HOW TO

Build any tall chord

1. **Start on the root** and skip one letter each time: 1 3 5 7 9 11 13.
2. **Stop** at the number in the name.
3. **Leave out** the 5th first; in a 13th chord, the 11th too, when it is too many notes for your hands.

THINK OF IT A tower block has a lift: you don't stop at every floor. Get out at the 3rd, the 7th and the top floor with the view.

TRAP

- × Hunting far up for the 9th: it is just the 2nd, an octave higher (D on C).
- × Calling C13 a C6: the 13th chord has the 7th (B♭) as well.
- × Playing F and E together in C13 or C11: they clash. C13 drops the F; C11 drops the E.

SEE ALSO
Seventh chords p. 99 · Colour chords p. 102

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 7 · Online: Library › Chords

PART IV · CHORDS · 8

Slash chords

C/E means one chord with a chosen bass note: play a C chord, with E as the lowest note. It is not a fraction, and not two chords.

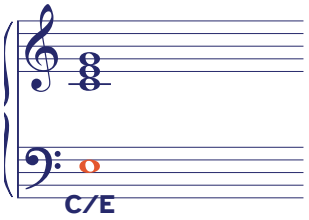
THE SECRET
Chord before the slash, bass note after it.

C/E

the chord
right hand

the bass
left hand, lowest note

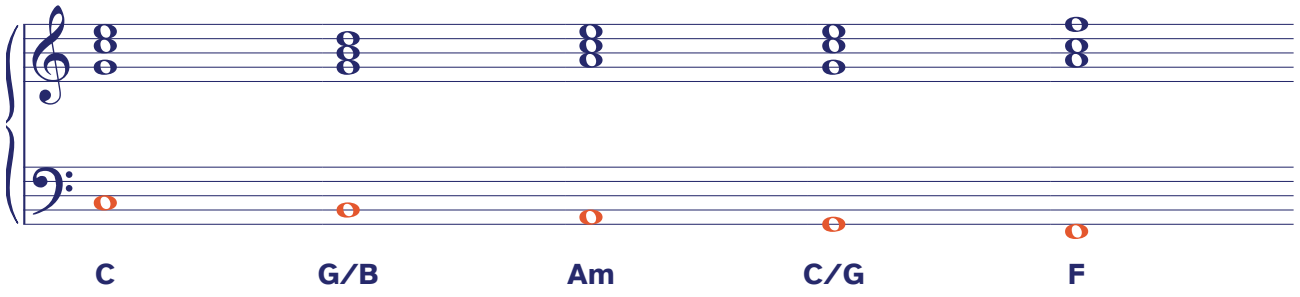
1. Before the slash: the **chord**. C means C E G, in the right hand.
2. After the slash: the **bass**. E goes in the left hand, below everything.
3. Play them together: **C/E**, “C over E”.



Four jobs for a slash chord

JOB	EXAMPLE	THE BASS NOTE IS	WHAT YOU HEAR
Inversion	C/E · C/G	a note of the chord	smoother changes (p. 96)
Walk-down	C · G/B · Am	one step down each time	a bass line that walks down
Pedal	F/C · G/C	the same note, held	chords move over a floor
Colour	F/G · D/C	not in the chord	open, modern: pop, gospel

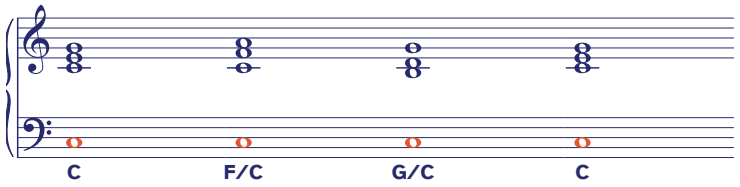
Job 2: a bass that walks down



The red bass walks straight down, C B A G F, while the right hand moves a step at most. G/B and C/G make the steps possible.

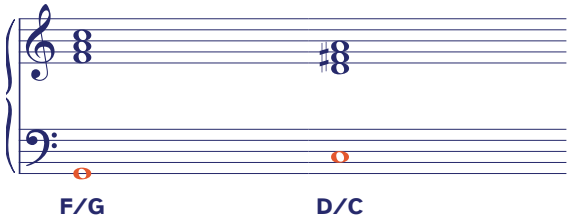
PART IV · CHORDS · 8 · CONTINUED

Job 3: a pedal, one bass under everything



The bass holds C while the chords change above it: C, F/C, G/C, C. The chords pull away from the C, then come home. (It is called a pedal after the organ's foot pedals, which hold long low notes.)

Job 4: a bass from outside the chord

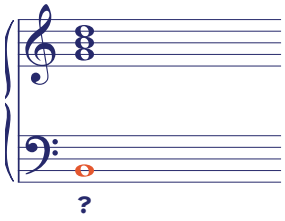


F/G: F A C over a G. G is not in the F chord, so it floats, open and unfinished, ready to land on C. Pop and gospel players love it.

D/C: D F♯ A over a C. The C is not in the D chord, so it rubs, then usually steps down to B (D/C to G/B).

EXAMPLE 1

Name it: G B D over a low B



1. **The right hand:** G B D, the G chord.
2. **The lowest note:** B, in the left hand.
3. **Chord, slash, bass:** G/B. B is in the G chord: an inversion.

It is **G/B**, "G over B": G major, 1st inversion.

GAME

Read the slash

1	2	3	4
G/B	C/G	F/A	Am/C

Before the slash: the chord. After it: the bass note. Which note goes in the left hand?

Answer: 1 B · 2 G · 3 A · 4 C.

PART IV · CHORDS · 8 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

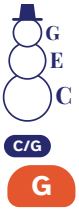


Right hand C, left hand E.

Play C E G in the right hand and a low E in the left: C/E. Now move the left hand to G: C/G. Same chord, new floor.

EXAMPLE 2

Play C/G

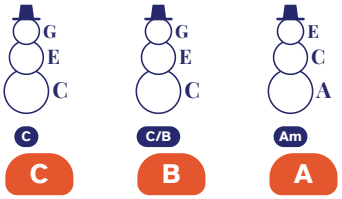


1. **Before the slash:** the chord, C E G, in the right hand.
2. **After the slash:** the bass note, a low G, in the left hand.
3. **Play them together.**

C/G: the C chord standing on a **G**.

EXAMPLE 3

Walk the bass down: C, C/B, Am



1. **Right hand** holds C E G for two chords.
2. **Left hand** walks down: C, then B.
3. **Then A**, under A C E: Am.

The bass walks **C B A**, one step at a time, while the chords hardly move.

THINK OF IT A house and the ground it stands on: the slash says what to build (the chord) and where to build it (the bass). Same house, new ground, new view.

TRAP

- × Writing it back to front: the chord comes first, the bass second. E/C would be an E chord over C.
- × Letting the right hand dip below the bass: the letter after the slash must be the lowest note you play.
- × Forgetting the chord itself: in C/E the right hand still plays the whole C chord, C E G, not just C.

SEE ALSO
Inversions p. 96 · Colour chords p. 102

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 8 · Online: Library › Chords

PART IV · CHORDS · TIPS

When a chord sounds wrong

A chord that sounds wrong usually has one small slip. Name the slip, fix that one note, and the chord comes right.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A chord sounds sour	**the kind**: keys between, 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	p. 90
Your hand jumps all over	**an inversion**: keep the shared note still	p. 96
A big chord sounds muddy	**leave notes out**: drop the 5th first	p. 105
A seventh chord sounds wrong	**the 7th**: G7 adds F, ten semitones above G	p. 99
A sus chord sounds unfinished	**the 4th**: it wants to fall one key to the 3rd	p. 102
The bass note sounds odd	**the slash**: the letter after it is the lowest note	p. 108

Four ways to learn chords fast

1. **Build, then play**
   Say the snowman (C E G) before your fingers go down.

2. **Hands alone first**
   Left hand chords alone, then the tune alone, then together.

3. **One trip a week**
   Learn one progression, then play it in three keys.

4. **Listen for the kind**
   Play major and minor side by side: bright, then dark.

EXAMPLE

Fix a sour chord



1. **It sounds dark**, but the music wants a bright C chord.
2. **Count the keys between:** 2, then 3. That is minor.
3. **Move one note:** E♭ up to E makes 3 + 2. Bright again.

One note was off: **fix the middle of the snowman**.

THINK OF IT Like a mechanic: one odd sound points to one part. Fix that part and the engine runs smoothly.